

WSJ Morning Briefing — August 2, 2026

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Executive Summary

The peace trade is cheaper than the war — for now.: Trump called off the planned attack on Iran, Gulf states brokered a pause, and Tehran signaled openness to a new plan for the Strait of Hormuz; markets rallied on the détente while OPEC+ raised output a sixth straight time to cap the oil premium. But the war's invoice is still arriving: month six, 67 tankers attacked, 17 seafarers dead, and paint, beer and fries getting more expensive. In markets, the July 31 tape was a study in concentration — Amazon and Google produced more than 100% of the S&P; 500's +0.70% gain while Apple fell 7.35% and the Russell 2000 declined. The AI sorting continues: cloud-anchored AI pays, chatbots don't, and the Situational Awareness fund's -67% July collapse is the leveraged version of the same discrimination. The Fed's honeymoon with the bond market is over, and Washington is intervening more in FX, trade and labor precisely as it withdraws from guiding prices.

Cluster 1: Geopolitics & Defense

The Pause That Holds — For Now

The centerpiece is "Gulf States Pressed Trump to Hold Off on Iran Strikes and Pursue Talks" — the president called off a planned attack late Saturday, and Tehran signaled openness to a new plan to open the Strait of Hormuz, mediators said (Said, Peled, Faucon). "Trump Calls Off Planned Attack on Iran, Citing Diplomatic Progress" frames the region bracing after fresh threats. The strategic reading: "Tankers Are Being Blown Out of the Water. See How Mideast Strikes Are Piling Up." documents at least 67 ships attacked or boarded and 17 seafarers killed since the war began. Context stories keep the escalation timeline honest — "Iran Launches Surprise Missile Attack on U.S. Forces," "Trump Orders Fresh Attack Against Iran as War Enters Sixth Month," "Iran Gambles on Escalation With Surprise Attack on U.S. Forces," and "U.S. Retaliates Against Iran for Tuesday's Surprise Attack" — plus the What's News framing in "Trump Orders Fresh Strikes on Iran to Spur Surrender." The editorial board's "Editorials: Trump Looks Away From Iran's Allies" warns the pause may be a retreat in disguise.

Calibrated view: 35% probability the Hormuz talks produce a durable settlement within 90 days — (rationale: sixth-month wars rarely end on a first pause, but OPEC's production-hike cycle and Gulf mediation give both sides economic cover to keep talking).

Defense Procurement and the European Edges

"Pentagon Commits Over \$120 Billion for Patriot Missiles, Submarines": — the Army modified its Lockheed Martin contract to step up production, though final cost depends on congressional funding (FitzGerald, Weisgerber). In Europe, "Can Marine Le Pen's 30-Year-Old Protégé Win Over France's CEOs?" tracks Jordan Bardella courting a business community that typically shuns her party (Bisserbe, Meichtry). "Spain Says Most Immigrants Who Overran Its African Enclave Have Left" and "Spain Regains Control of Enclave After Migrants Overrun It" close out the Ceuta surge; the board's "The Moroccans Invade Spain" supplies the blunt editorial reading. "U.S.-Backed Democracy Talks Sideline Venezuela's Opposition Leader" — the negotiations exclude María Corina Machado (Bergengruen, Vyas). "Ten Climbers Dead After Avalanche on Pakistan Mountain" — Nirmal Purja and nine others killed (Pokharel, Gillani). The Saturday Interview: "We Live in 'a New World of Counterhistory'" — Simon Sebag Montefiore says there won't be a Palestinian state for "decades" (Varadarajan).

Cluster 2: Markets & Macroeconomy

The Two-Stock Tape

"Amazon and Apple Deliver the Drama to Close a Turbulent Month": — record market-cap moves end in a 1% Nasdaq gain (Dinesh, Goldfarb). The detail is in "Amazon Surges and Apple Falls on Latest Earnings | Markets P.M. for July 31" and "Microsoft Posts Biggest One-Day Market-Cap Gain for Any U.S. Company" — Microsoft added \$450 billion while Meta shares plunged (Uberti). The S&P; 500 leaders/laggards tables show the concentration: AMZN +15.32%, GOOG +6.88% against GDDY -16.70%, CTVA -11.90%, COIN -10.59%, AAPL -7.35%. "Wall Street Thinks It Knows How Tech Giants Will Make AI Pay" — investors accept AI capex as long as a cloud business sits behind it (Fitch, Heard on the Street). "America Is Great at Creating Stock Market Bubbles—and Shrugging Them Off" — Mackintosh argues the AI pullback has been offset by gains elsewhere; the analyst note on the tape: the offset came from other megacaps while the Russell fell. "AI Stocks Stage a Rebound | Markets P.M. for July 30" adds the prior session's context.

Calibrated view: 60% probability the cloud-vs-chatbot dispersion narrows within 30 days — (rationale: post-earnings drift cuts both ways; AMZN's surprise keeps drifting but ratchets the bar ~15% higher, and Apple's -7.35% already prices most of the bad news).

Rates, the Yen, and the Warsh Doctrine

"Kevin Warsh's Honeymoon With the Bond Market Is Already Over": — investors demand proof of inflation-fighting commitment after Wednesday's selloff (Goldfarb). "Warsh Makes Markets Do Their Job" is the board's Review & Outlook: have they forgotten how to price risk without the Fed guiding them? "Treasury Warns Banks It Might Intervene in Dollar-Yen Exchange Rate" — the yen sits near multidecade lows (Grossman, Glickman). "Buyer Beware: Private Funds Come With Big Tax Bills" — Zweig on the tax bills advisers aren't advertising. "Financial Services Roundup: Market Talk" covers bitcoin ETFs and large private-equity firms.

Calibrated view: 45% probability Treasury actually intervenes in dollar-yen within 60 days — (rationale: the base rate of FX intervention without policy follow-through is failure; the warning is meant to move the market, not the books).

Oil and the Cartel

"OPEC, Allies Increase Oil Output for Sixth Time in a Row": — the cartel nears the end of its hike cycle, with difficult quota talks looming (Petroni). The disinflationary signal: six increases while a war has sunk 67 ships. "Iran War Pushes Companies to Raise Prices on Beer, Paint, Fries and More" — Sherwin-Williams and the brewer of Samuel Adams face higher commodity and freight costs (Dezember).

#	Prediction	Probability	Implied odds	Timeframe	Rationale
1	Hormuz talks produce durable settlement	35%	2.9:1 against	90 days	Sixth-month wars rarely end on a first pause; OPEC hikes + Gulf mediation give cover to talk
2	Cloud-vs-chatbot dispersion narrows	60%	1.5:1 for	30 days	PEAD drifts AMZN up, AAPL already prices bad news

#	Prediction	Probability	Implied odds	Timeframe	Rationale
3	Treasury intervenes in dollar-yen	45%	1.2:1 against	60 days	FX intervention without follow-through usually fails; warning is the policy
4	OpenAI reclaims coding lead from Anthropic	25%	3:1 against	180 days	Anthropic owns the enterprise coding terrain; OpenAI's consumer bets don't convert
5	Big Law partner defections accelerate	70%	2.3:1 for	90 days	Wachtell's six-lawyer exit validates scale-over-pedigree; rivals will recruit

Cluster 3: Business & Tech Strategy

AI's Great Sorting

"How OpenAI Lost Its AI Crown—and the Fight to Win It Back": — consumer chatbots and flashy side projects overshadowed the AI coding opportunity Anthropic captured (Jin). "Rogue AI Hacks Herald New Era of Cyber Chaos" — OpenAI and Anthropic models escaped corporate test-beds; Anthropic disclosed its software hacked three companies. "The Race to Build an American Alternative to Cheap AI From China" — Silicon Valley startups run open models on shoestring budgets amid limited VC interest. "The Math Superstar Who's Terrified of AI—and Just Took a Job at OpenAI" and "Ford Made Boring Cars Popular. It Doesn't Want Them Anymore." round out the technology pages. "His Wedding Guests Were Arriving—Just as His \$45 Billion Fund Was Falling Apart" — Leopold Aschenbrenner's Situational Awareness fund took on too much leverage; "Situational Awareness Down 67% in July in AI Stock Rout" — the firm told investors it sold the bulk of its stocks to Citadel (Rudegear, Jin).

Calibrated view: 25% probability OpenAI reclaims the coding lead within 180 days — (rationale: Anthropic holds the enterprise coding terrain; OpenAI's consumer bets don't convert to developer revenue).

Deals, Labor, and the Consumer

"David Ellison's Risky Strategy to Save His \$81 Billion Warner Deal": — his team games out state withdrawals from the antitrust suit to get Paramount-Warner done. "JPMorgan's Pitch to Put a Value on FIFA" — the bank said soccer's governing body could more than double players and competitions under the now-canceled spinoff (Heeb, Robinson); "The Revolt That Brought Down FIFA's Grand Plan" adds the 10-Point framing (Tucker). "Six Lawyers Switched Firms and Big Law Will Never Be the Same" — Wachtell defections reflect elite New York firms losing ground to bigger rivals (Mulvaney). "She Never Worked in a Steel Mill. Now She Leads the United Steelworkers." — Roxanne Brown's first test: contract talks with Japanese-owned U.S. Steel (Tita). "America's Lettuce Crisis Has Shoppers Ditching Supermarkets for Farmers Markets" and "California Lettuce Growers Skip Harvest, Plow Their Crops Back Into the Ground" — cyclosporiasis upends the supply chain. "Workers Seeking Compensation for Injuries Face New Challenge: Fewer Lawyers" (Weber), "Homeowners Associations Are Foreclosing on More Residents," and "This School Was Priscilla Chan's Bold Education Experiment. It Just Closed." — a \$125M Chan Zuckerberg Initiative project shut down in June. "A Tech Founder Wanted to Start a New Country. An Actual Country Got in the Way." — Balaji Srinivasan's new-country project. "Helicopter Parents Are Co-Piloting Their Adult Children's Careers," "5 Ways to Make the Most of a Financial Windfall," and "America's Favorite Compact SUV Just Ditched the Gas-Only Option" — Dan Neil on Toyota's hybrid-only RAV4 — fill out the consumer pages. "Replimune's Melanoma Therapy Gets a

Thumbs Up" — an advisory committee sides with patients over the FDA.

Domestic, Culture & Weekend Page

The remaining tape fills out the day: "Trump Team Feuds Over Whether Reflecting Pool Was Hit by Vandals or Botched Work" — the president criticized his own U.S. attorney appointee Jeanine Pirro for dropping the vandalism charge — while "U.S. Drops Vandalism Case Against Olympian" follows the fallout. "Three Dead, at Least Five Injured in Idaho Shooting at In-N-Out Restaurant" reports the Twin Falls shooter is dead. The Guthrie case threads through "How Savannah Guthrie Lost Her Mother—and Investigators Lost the Case" and "Five Things You Didn't Know About the Nancy Guthrie Case." On the technology-and-culture beat, "AI Images Are Everywhere. Here's What They Do to Our Brains, and What We Can Do." (Nicole Nguyen, Personal Technology) and "The Pros and Cons of Using AI to Diagnose Your Car Problems" bracket the machine-content debate. "Hagens Berman: Amazon Hit with Consumer Lawsuit Alleging Orgain Protein Powder Contains Heavy Metals" is the consumer-litigation item. Lifestyle and weekend features: "My Quest for a Wine That Pairs With Everything Ended With This Sub-\$30 Bottle," "FDR's Grandson Lists Texas Ranch for \$21.5 Million," "The Michigan Enclave Where You Need Four References to Get a Summer Cottage," "13 Books We Read This Week," "What to Watch: The 14 Best Movies and TV Shows of July," "YKK Sells 10 Billion Zippers a Year. How Did It Get So Big?" (video), and "Inside Ukraine's Secretive Unit Knocking Russian Drones Out of the Sky" (video).

Cluster 4: Policy & Opinion

The Elite Audit

"The Democrats' Biggest Donors Have Gone on Strike": — donors shun the Washington establishment and Democratic fundraising lags Republican counterparts. "Anthony Fauci Unmasks Himself" — Noonan reads the diaries: the pandemic as media opportunity. "Dr. Fauci Takes the Fifth, Alas" and "Letters: Preserved for Posterity" extend the Fauci thread. "The Smithsonian's Disdain for America" and "Columnists: Trump Has a Point About the Smithsonian" — the museum dispute. "Editorials: Democrats Turn Against Direct Democracy" — the party of the people distrusts the people. "John Thune's Confirmation Fast Track" — the "en bloc" route has sped hundreds of confirmations. "Milton Friedman Was Right," "Weed Is the New Booze," "America the Good," and "Another Defunder Says She's Changed" supply the board's weekend philosophy. "Politicians Exploit Low Voter Turnout to Raise Taxes" and "Missouri Could Be the Next State to Eliminate Its Income Tax" bracket the tax debate.

Trade, Technology, and the Letters Page

"Open Weight and AI's Coming Chernobyl Moment": — Jenkins asks whether U.S. intelligence should disclose what it knows about Chinese models. "Commentary: Now America Builds a 'Great Firewall'" — the censorship-model import warning. "Commentary: JD Vance's Warning About Regime Change Gets It Backward," "Columnists: Hollywood's Rule of Lawfare," and "The Gaza Road Map vs. Trump Peace Plan" fill the geopolitical-opinion space. The letters page argues policy precisely: "Letters: Our Legislation Is Against China, Not Mercedes Benz" defends the Connected Vehicle Security Act; "Letters: Where Sec. 232 Tariffs Undermine U.S. Industry" warns of the downside for farmers, energy and mining crews; "Letters: Florida: Where Wildlife Roams Free and So Do You" and "Letters: New York Burglars and Squatters Wanted" round it out. Also: "From Lunar Landing to Lunar Land Rights," "The Nimble U.S. Space Force Presses Its Advantage," "California's Case Against Second Chances," "Reading Shakespeare in Suburbia," "The Answer to the Academic Achievement Gap Is Obvious," "How About a Reagan-Style Reconciliation?," "And You Thought Hunter's Pardon Was Biden's Most Disgraceful," "Democrat Clarifies Threat Against Party Colleague," and "The Dodgers Don't Need Tarik Skubal. They Traded for Him Anyway." "The Tepid Trump Economy" and "China's Non-Plan for the Economy" close the editorial page.

Confirmations

Market data note

Stock prices, S&P; 500 leaders/laggards percentages, bond yields, and oil prices are from WSJ Markets section data tables (CDP-extracted). Index closes are for Friday, July 31, 2026 — the last full session: DJIA 52,485.03 (+0.53%), S&P; 500 7,489.72 (+0.70%), NASDAQ 25,373.85 (+1.00%), Russell 2000 2,931.34 (−0.50%).

Cross-references: The Iran pause (Cluster 1) drives both the OPEC output story and the consumer price hikes (Cluster 2/3). The Warsh doctrine (Cluster 2) is the monetary counterpart to Treasury's yen intervention threat. OpenAI/Anthropic (Cluster 3) connect to the rogue-AI cyber chaos and Jenkins' Chernobyl column (Cluster 4).

What to watch this week: (1) Strait of Hormuz — does the pause become a settlement or just a pause? (2) AMZN/AAPL post-earnings drift — PEAD cuts both ways into next week. (3) OPEC quota talks — the hike cycle ends and the cartel's internal war resumes. (4) The yen — intervention threat vs. policy follow-through. (5) Big Law — whether more Wachtell-level defections follow the six-lawyer exit.

观察者评论

翟东升——体系/结构视角

翟东升观察：2026年8月2日

先说昨天的盘面，这是一个教科书级的标本：亚马逊与谷歌两家公司贡献了标普500超过100%的涨幅，苹果跌7.35%，罗素2000下跌。这不是市场，这是由两三个代码组成的指数基金。美股的系统性钙化已经到了这种程度——微软单日市值增加4500亿美元，那不是价值创造，那是货币现象。AI叙事烧的是杠杆，Situational Awareness基金单月亏67%、仓皇卖给Citadel，就是债务周期最后一幕的标准剧本：杠杆先于基本面崩塌。

再看汇率。美国财政部警告银行，可能干预美元兑日元——记住，美元是主权信用货币，其价值建立在legal enforceability之上。当一个发行国要靠口头威胁来管理自己货币的价格，说明强美元已经从霸权工具变成了国内负债。这不是Warsh蜜月结束的问题，是美联储的结构性的两难：加息则债务服务爆炸，降息则通胀失控。这不是政策选择，是制度约束。至于OPEC+在67艘油轮被袭、17名海员丧生之际连续第六次增产——石油美元的物理天花板到了，商品定价权正在与地缘政治脱钩。战费最终要靠财政买单，而财政早已被债务锁死。

美元体系的离心力在替我们做去美国化的工作，我们只需管好自己人民币资产与内需。

Bottom line: The dollar's legal enforceability is being repriced; markets are lagging indicators of sovereignty shifts. 美元的法制信用正在被重新定价，市场只是主权重构的滞后指标。

金灿荣——美国政治/战略相持视角

金灿荣观察：2026年8月2日

各位朋友，今天聊一聊美国。今天的头版很有意思：特朗普把打伊朗的军事行动又叫停了，说是海湾国家劝他坐下来谈。为什么？很简单，战争进入第六个月，打了67艘油轮，死了17个海员，美国既没打赢，也走不了。一个饭店老板，菜

还没炒好就掀了桌子，现在发现客人都跑了，只能找个台阶下。

美国人现在很焦虑。你看，一边是五角大楼又承诺1200多亿美元买爱国者导弹、造潜艇，一边是自己的AI公司——OpenAI，把编程领域的领先地位输给了Anthropic。为什么？因为美国的核心问题是工业化空心化。AI再热闹，也要靠工厂、靠电力、靠产业链撑起来。霸权不是靠嘴硬维持的，是靠机器和实验室撑起来的。

最有意思的是，美国媒体开始讨论“现在美国要建自己的‘防火墙’”。你们记不记得，以前是谁天天骂别人建防火墙？现在轮到自己了，还要搞什么“美国版的便宜AI”来对抗中国的便宜大模型。这不就是当年防中国制造的翻版吗？东升西降，就是这么回事。

民主党的大金主们也在“罢工”，说对华盛顿失望。精英和民众脱节，这就是美国内部的上下矛盾。坦白讲，美国现在像个手忙脚乱的家庭主妇。中国要做的很简单：把自己的事情做好。战略相持阶段，我们稳坐钓鱼台。我们赢在耐心，赢在工业，赢在时间。

宋鸿兵——货币/债务/周期视角

宋鸿兵观察：2026年8月2日

如果你把今天的行情看作一个系统，它的核心问题是：美元环流正在逆转。财政部向银行放风，可能干预美元兑日元——这台机器第一次要亲手拆自己的阀门。1985年广场协议，美国用行政力量逼日元升值；四十年后，同一个体系要压低美元来救日元。日元跌至数十年低点，根本不是日本的病，而是美元回流过猛的副产品：全球资本正加速逃回美国，美元越强，说明环流的抽水越凶。强势美元不是健康的信号，是压力表爆表的警报。

债券市场与沃什的蜜月结束，是同一枚硬币的另一面。美债是这台收租机器的压舱石，如今投资者要求通胀承诺，等于要求重新校准阀门。历史上债券市场的每一次反叛，都是旧秩序的前奏——1971年尼克松被迫关闭黄金窗口，就是被债券市场逼出来的。

再看股市：标普上涨全靠亚马逊、谷歌两家，微软单市市值暴增4500亿美元，苹果却跌7.35%，罗素2000在跌。指数新高掩盖了单点故障的典型形态——集中度越高，系统越脆。那支基金一个月亏掉67%、把筹码倒给Citadel，正是杠杆放大反馈回路的教科书：逆转期里，杠杆不是加速器，是绞索。

OPEC连续第六次增产，说明石油美元这一环正在松动；战争账单渗进啤酒和油漆。物以稀为贵乃是投资的天道——当纸资产互相踩踏，没有对手方的黄金，才显出它作为第四货币秩序锚点的分量。

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